EU-LEAP · CAIRO WATER WEEK 2026

Egypt has the water engineers. It's short of the first buyer.

What one day of bankers, ministers and graduates told us · 28 Oct

AA

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THE BRIEF

3 questions every young water firm has to answer

1 **Who buys?**
A utility, ministry or factory ready to sign the order

2 **Who finances?**
A lender or investor able to price the risk

3 **Who validates?**
A test site or research centre that proves it works

Asked by H.E. Angelina Eichhorst, EU Ambassador to Egypt

DEMAND IS REAL

The buyers are already building

4.8 bn m³ a year added by national reuse plants

55,000 km of canals and drains digitised

12 NWRC institutes open to company pilots

Next shift: from mega plants to decentralised treatment. A market for Egyptian SMEs in modular units, O&M and monitoring.

Minister of Water Resources and Irrigation, 28 Oct 2026

THE SKILLS GAP

Strong engineers. Thin commercial skills.

2.7 /5

How graduates rate their readiness for the job market
Live poll, 23 responses

~30%
of research publications taken up by companies (NWRC)

#1
missing skill: contracts, costs and finance

THE FIRST-CONTRACT TRAP

Banks want a track record. A first contract is how you get one.

> *Nobody is working to fill this gap.*

Fireside chat: From Campus Pilot to Purchase Order

Top poll answer on the barrier: "no buyer willing to take a risk on a first-time firm or product."

A PROPOSED RISK SPLIT

Who carries what on a first deployment

1 **Public side**
Policy, land and payment risk

2 **Private partner**
Execution and performance risk

3 **Technology firm**
Early-stage risk

4 **Development funders**
Guarantees and insurance

Proposed by 10 round tables moderated by Galala University

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The recap:

- Demand is real: reuse, digitisation, decentralised treatment
- Graduates rate their readiness 2.7 / 5. Finance skills lag most
- **The missing rung is the first buyer**
- Split first-deployment risk across 4 parties

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Who should place Egypt's first order for an untested water technology?

The utility, the ministry, or the funder?

Answer in the comments

Personal views. Not EU policy or a funding commitment.

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